Lead Broker Blueprint by Lorenzo Marietti

Module 4 — The Buyer Side

Landing Your First Buyer Relationships

The buyer-discovery, outreach, pitch, and negotiation playbook — for the operator with no track record and no existing buyer relationships.

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How to use this playbook

Module 4 (The Buyer Side) tells you what buyers are, how they think, what they pay for, and what their contracts look like. This playbook tells you how to actually land your first three buyer relationships — the most critical and most painful phase of building a lead-brokering business.

The honest truth: most new operators die in this phase. They generate leads, struggle to find anyone to sell them to, run out of cash before closing their first buyer relationship, and quit. Operators who survive this phase do four things differently: they research buyers carefully before pitching, they pitch with specificity and proof of work, they negotiate the LPA terms that protect both sides, and they treat the first buyer relationship as the foundation everything else gets built on.

This playbook gives you the scripts, frameworks, and decisions to survive the first six months. Read it once start to finish. Come back to Part 6 (negotiation) every time you sit down to redline a new LPA.

Three operating principles

1. The buyer is solving a problem; you are part of the solution, not the product.

New operators pitch their lead-generation capabilities. Experienced operators pitch the buyer's business outcome. The framing difference shows up in every interaction — outreach emails, pitch decks, discovery calls — and it changes whether the buyer treats you as a vendor (interchangeable) or as a partner (defensible).

2. Specificity is your only competitive advantage when you have no track record.

You have no case studies. You have no testimonials. You have no logos. The one thing you DO have is the ability to know more about this buyer's specific situation than every other vendor pitching them. That asymmetric homework — done before the first email — is what gets you in the door.

3. The first relationship sets the template for every relationship after it.

How you negotiate, deliver, communicate, and resolve disputes with your first buyer becomes your operating standard. Get it right, and it scales. Get it wrong, and you'll be unlearning bad habits for years. Take more time on the first buyer than you think you need.

Part 1 — The buyer landscape audit

Before you write a single outreach message, you need a working map of who buys leads in your chosen vertical, what they pay, how they buy, and who specifically inside each firm makes the buying decision.

Step 1 — Identify the buyer categories

Almost every vertical has 3-6 distinct buyer categories. Examples:

HVAC replacement

- Independent local contractors (1-5 trucks). Decision-maker: the owner. Volume: 5-15 leads/month.
- Regional contractor chains (10-50 locations). Decision-maker: marketing director or VP of operations. Volume: 50-300 leads/month.
- Aggregator networks (Networx, Modernize, HomeAdvisor). Decision-maker: vendor-onboarding manager. Volume: high, but you become their inventory.
- Manufacturer-affiliated contractor networks (Carrier Authorized Dealers, Lennox Premier). Decision-maker: regional brand manager + dealer-development team.
- Private-equity-owned home services rollups (Wrench Group, ARS/Rescue Rooter). Decision-maker: corporate marketing director.

Personal injury

- Solo and small-firm attorneys (1-10 attorneys). Decision-maker: managing partner. Volume: 5-25 leads/month.
- Mid-size PI firms (10-50 attorneys). Decision-maker: intake director or marketing director. Volume: 50-300 leads/month.
- National PI brands (Morgan & Morgan, JG Wentworth Law Group). Decision-maker: VP of marketing + vendor-management team.
- Mass-tort lead aggregators (X Social Media, Settle My Claim, others). Decision-maker: case acquisition manager.
- Lawyer-owned referral and intake networks. Decision-maker: network operations manager.

Medicare

- FMOs (Field Marketing Organizations) — Integrity, Senior Market Sales, AmeriLife, TogetherHealth. Decision-maker: marketing acquisition lead.
- Direct insurers and licensed brokerage networks (eHealth, GoHealth, SelectQuote). Decision-maker: vendor-management or paid-media director.

- Independent agencies (multi-carrier brokers). Decision-maker: owner-operator. Volume: 10-50 leads/month.
- Captive agent networks (UHC, Humana captive teams). Decision-maker: regional sales director.

Mortgage

- Independent mortgage brokers. Decision-maker: owner or lead loan officer.
- Mid-size mortgage banks (community lenders). Decision-maker: marketing director.
- Retail mortgage divisions of large lenders (Rocket, UWM, Pennymac retail). Decision-maker: paid-media manager or vendor-management.
- Aggregators (LendingTree, Bankrate). Decision-maker: vendor onboarding.

Step 2 — Pick the right category for your situation

Most new operators should NOT start by pitching the largest buyers. The math is counterintuitive but consistent:

- Large buyers (national brands, PE rollups, aggregators) have lower friction to test you (they buy from many vendors) but they have specialized vendor-management teams who screen out new operators ruthlessly. Acceptance rate from cold outreach: ~5%.
- Mid-size buyers (regional firms) have moderate screening and care most about reliability. Acceptance rate: ~12%.
- Small buyers (solo operators, single-location firms) have the highest acceptance rate (~25-35%) but the lowest individual volume. The path: land 5-15 small buyers in your first 90 days, prove out delivery, then use those references to climb.

Recommendation for first-buyer pursuit: start with mid-size firms (the sweet spot of acceptance rate × volume) supplemented by 3-5 small buyers for cushion.

Step 3 — Build the target list (50-150 names)

For your chosen buyer category and geography, build a target list of 50-150 specific firms. Sources:

- Industry associations and directories — NAR for real estate, AAJ for plaintiff attorneys, AHRI for HVAC contractors, NAIFA for insurance agents, AMBA for mortgage bankers.
- State licensing boards — searchable databases of licensed contractors, attorneys, insurance agents in your geography.
- LinkedIn search — "PI attorney Florida", filtered by firm size.
- Industry conferences' past attendee lists — published partial lists let you see who's actively buying or selling.
- Local BBB directories, Yelp/Google Maps for service businesses.

- Existing aggregator vendor pages — Modernize, HomeAdvisor, LendingTree show which firms they're sourcing from.
- Specialty databases — Listsource, Cole Information, ZoomInfo for buyer firmographics + decision-maker identification.

For each target, capture in your CRM: firm name, geography, estimated size, the most likely decision-maker (name + role + LinkedIn URL), any known mutual connections, and what you specifically know about their current vendor situation (active or passive).

Step 4 — Score and prioritize

Score each target on three factors, 1-3:

- Match score (1-3) — how well your specific lead product fits their buying profile.
- Approachability score (1-3) — warm intro available (3), mutual LinkedIn connection (2), pure cold (1).
- Buying-active score (1-3) — actively buying leads now (3), known to have bought historically (2), unknown (1).

Sum the three. Anyone scoring 7-9 goes in your week-one outreach batch. 5-6 goes in week 2-3. 3-4 stays on a quarterly check-in cadence. Update scoring as you learn.

Part 2 — The outreach sequences

Five channels, used in combination per target: warm intro (preferred), LinkedIn DM, email, voice/voicemail, and conference-floor introduction. Every successful first-buyer relationship comes from a combination of these touches — almost never from a single channel.

The combined sequence (one target, 21-day arc)

1. Day 0 — LinkedIn connection request with a custom note (one sentence).
2. Day 3 — Email #1 (vertical-specific cold open, see scripts below).
3. Day 7 — LinkedIn message (assume connection accepted; if not, skip).
4. Day 12 — Email #2 ("following up + adding new context").
5. Day 16 — Voicemail (if direct line available).
6. Day 21 — Email #3 ("the breakup" — final touch).

Stop after Day 21. Move to quarterly check-in cadence. Most positive responses arrive at touch 2-4; some arrive at touch 5-6 from buyers who got too busy at touches 1-2.

Scripts — Email

Email #1 — Cold open (HVAC example)

Subject lines that consistently outperform:

- "3 estimate-ready leads for [City] this week — sample inside"
- "[Specific competitor / peer firm] referred me to you" (only if true)
- "Question on your lead-vendor mix"

> *Hi [First Name], I'm [Your Name], founder at [Your Operation]. I produce exclusive HVAC replacement leads in [Metro] and the surrounding ZIPs — homeowners, system 10+ years, ASAP-to-90-day timeline, qualified by phone before delivery. I noticed [specific thing about their business — a recent expansion, a service-area note from their site, a recent hire]. Wondering if your current vendor mix is delivering enough volume to support [observed thing], or if you'd be open to a no-commitment test with 5-10 leads to compare. I'd send the first sample with full consent documentation so you can see the quality before any conversation about terms. Worth a 15-minute call next Tuesday or Thursday? [Signature with phone + LinkedIn]*

Why this works: opens with the buyer's business outcome (volume to support their expansion), not your product. Demonstrates research (the specific thing). Lowers the perceived risk ("no-commitment test", "send the first sample"). Closes with a specific, low-friction CTA. Under 130 words.

Email #2 — Follow-up with new context

> *Hi [First Name], Following up on the note last week. Quick update on what I've shipped since then: [3 leads in your area delivered this morning to [other buyer if they consented to be referenced] / a new buyer onboarded this week / new TrustedForm + recording capture process live in our intake]. I want to make this concrete. Happy to send you 2-3 actual recent leads (anonymized PII) so you can see the qualification depth and the consent disclosures we capture. No expectation of a buy on this — just so you have a real reference point. Worth the 15 minutes? [Signature]*

Email #3 — The breakup

> *Hi [First Name], Reaching out one last time. Three notes I'll send you, then I'll stop unless you say so: (1) The full intake flow I described, with consent documentation: [Link / attached PDF]. (2) Two anonymized recent leads showing the qualification depth: [Link / attached]. (3) My direct line if you'd ever want to talk: [Phone]. No response is response enough — I won't keep cluttering your inbox. If we ever cross paths at LeadsCon or [vertical conference], coffee is on me. Best, [Your name]*

Operators consistently report 8-15% response rates from the breakup email alone — buyers who'd ignored earlier touches respond because the tone reads as confident and respectful.

Scripts — LinkedIn

Connection request (250-char limit)

> *Hi [First Name] — I produce exclusive HVAC leads in [Metro] and noticed [specific thing about their firm]. Wondering if I can ask a quick question about your current lead-vendor mix. Either way, glad to connect.*

First DM after connect

> *Thanks for connecting, [First Name]. Quick question — are you currently buying from one or two specific lead vendors in [Metro], or do you have an open vendor list? I'm not asking to pitch right now; just trying to understand the buyer landscape in your geography. If it's helpful context for you, happy to share what I'm seeing on the supply side.*

Why this works: not a pitch. Asks a real question. Offers value (intelligence about supply). Opens the door without forcing them through it.

Scripts — Voicemail

Voicemails work because almost no vendors leave them. Voicemails done WELL work even better. 30 seconds max.

> *Hi [First Name], this is [Your Name] with [Your Operation] — I sent you an email last week and a LinkedIn note. I produce HVAC leads in [Metro] and I think there's a possible fit with what [their firm] is doing. I don't want to keep clogging your email — figured I'd just call. My direct line is [number]; you can also text me there. No pressure, but if there's any interest, that's the easiest path. Thanks [First Name], talk soon.*

Key elements: identify yourself + the prior touches (so they know you're not random), state the specific vertical and geography, give them a direct line for low-friction reply (call or text), set a respectful tone.

Scripts — Conference-floor introduction

30 seconds, standing up, drink in hand. Pitch slot in conversation: when the other person says "so what do you do?"

> *I run a lead-gen operation focused on [specific sub-vertical] in [geography]. Right now I'm shipping about [volume] qualified [type] leads a week and looking to add 2-3 more buyer relationships in that profile. Are you currently buying leads in that space? [They answer.] Who's your current vendor — anyone good? I'm always looking for benchmarks. // [If yes:] What does "good" look like for you on a lead in that profile? // [If no:] If I sent you 5 sample leads to look at, no commitment, would that be useful?*

Conferences reward operators who ask questions. Almost everyone there is pitching. Almost no one is asking. Become the operator who asks substantive questions and you become memorable.

Part 3 — The buyer pitch one-pager

After the outreach lands and the buyer agrees to a call (or before, if they ask for materials), you send a one-page document that summarizes your operation. NOT a 12-slide deck. NOT a video sales letter. ONE page that a busy intake director can read in 90 seconds and forward to their boss.

The structure

Top to bottom, one page, ~350 words total:

Section 1 — Headline (1 sentence)

> *[Your operation] produces [specific qualifier] [type] leads in [geography], with [headline differentiator].*

Example: "RestoreLine Lead Group produces homeowner-verified HVAC replacement leads in Tampa, Orlando, and Jacksonville, with full TrustedForm consent capture and phone-qualified delivery."

Section 2 — The lead profile (5-7 bullets)

Exactly what a lead from you looks like. Examples:

- Vertical and sub-vertical: HVAC replacement, homeowners only
- Geographic scope: Tampa metro, Orlando metro, Jacksonville metro (specific MSAs)
- Volume: 30-60 qualified leads per week, currently
- Qualification: phone-verified homeowner, system age 8+ years, timeline 0-90 days, not already engaged with another contractor
- Compliance: TrustedForm certificate URL with every lead, FCC one-to-one consent, call recording (FL two-party consent compliant)
- Delivery method: phone warm transfer (live), form post (instant API), or scheduled callback (consumer preference)

Section 3 — Sources (2-3 bullets)

- Paid search (Google Ads, primary)
- NextDoor, Meta lookalikes (secondary)
- Direct-mail-to-digital retargeting on permit-trigger lists (experimental)

Section 4 — Pricing (concrete)

- Standard rate: $XX per qualified estimate appointment, exclusive
- Volume tier discounts available at [thresholds]
- Returns honored within [time window] for [defined return reasons]

- Payment terms: [terms]

Section 5 — How to start (1-2 sentences)

> *"30-day pilot, 5-10 leads to evaluate quality. No long-term commitment. We agree on definition of 'qualified' upfront. If the pilot meets your standard, we sign a standard LPA and ramp volume."*

Section 6 — Footer

- Your name, role, phone, email, LinkedIn URL
- Operation name and legal entity (if formed)
- "References available on request" — even if you have none yet, this is appropriate phrasing

What NOT to include

- Generic marketing copy ("trusted by industry leaders since 2026"). Buyers see through it instantly.
- Fake or inflated numbers. The vendor-management folks WILL check.
- Vague guarantees ("highest quality leads in the industry"). Show, don't tell.
- Logos of brands you haven't sold to. This is grounds for immediate disqualification.
- Long-form case studies. They go in a separate document the buyer can request.

Part 4 — The discovery call playbook

When the buyer agrees to a 15-30 minute call, your job is NOT to pitch. Your job is to learn enough about their operation that you can either (a) make a precise, fitted recommendation, or (b) recognize that the fit isn't there and disqualify yourself gracefully. The buyers who hire you are the ones who left the call feeling that you listened more than you talked.

Pre-call preparation (15-20 minutes)

- Review their public website thoroughly. Note service areas, team size, recent hires (LinkedIn), recent press releases.
- Check their Google Reviews and BBB profile. Note customer-experience signals.
- Search their domain in industry publications for any quotes, articles, or interviews from the decision-maker.
- Look up their last 5 LinkedIn posts. Note what they care about.
- If they're publicly listed somewhere as a vendor for an aggregator, note who their other suppliers might be.
- Prepare a clean intake form for the call: 12-15 questions to capture answers.

The call structure (30 min target)

Open (3 minutes)

- Thank them for the time. Briefly recap who you are and what you produce (under 30 seconds — don't repeat the one-pager).
- Set the agenda: "I want to spend most of this call understanding your operation and your current vendor mix. I'll be ready to talk about whether and how we might work together at the end if it makes sense."

Discover (20 minutes)

Ask these in order. Listen 4x more than you talk:

7. Tell me about your operation. How many [contractors / attorneys / agents], how many years, what's your current monthly lead volume target?
8. Where are leads coming from today? Which vendors, which channels, in what proportions?
9. What does an ideal lead look like for you? Walk me through the qualification spec — what you need it to look like to be worth your acquisition cost.
10. Where are your current vendors falling short? Not by name — just the gaps.
11. What's your conversion rate from lead to [appointment / consult / deal]? (If they share — many buyers won't.)

12. What's your current cost per qualified lead and what's the ceiling you'd pay for a clearly better one?
13. What happens after a lead arrives? Walk me through your intake process.
14. How do you handle disputes? Bad leads, returns, the gray-area stuff.
15. What's your payment process — Net 30, prepaid, weekly settlements?
16. What would make you say no to a new vendor right now?
17. What would make you say yes?
18. Who else has to be involved in this decision on your side?

Recap and propose (5 minutes)

- Briefly summarize what you heard.
- State whether you think you're a fit, honestly. If you're not, say so — the buyer will remember you for it, and they'll refer you to firms where you ARE the fit.
- If you are a fit, propose the next concrete step: send 3-5 sample leads, schedule a follow-up call, or skip straight to a 30-day pilot.
- Confirm timeline and next-step owner.

Close (2 minutes)

- Confirm the next step in writing — "I'll send a follow-up email today with [exact deliverables] and a draft pilot agreement."
- Thank them again. End on time.

Red flags to watch for

- Buyer can't articulate their qualification spec clearly. If they don't know what "qualified" means, every lead will be disputed. Walk away or insist on writing the spec together before signing.
- Buyer wants to negotiate price before seeing leads. Often a tell that they're going to grind your margins down once you're locked in. Reframe: "Let's see if the quality justifies the rate first."
- Buyer mentions a long list of vendors they've fired. Some of that is normal; an entire history of fired vendors is usually about THEM, not the vendors.
- Buyer pushes for exclusivity in the first conversation. Exclusivity should be a Tier 1 conversation 3-6 months in, not a first-call demand. If they push, ask why — sometimes it's reasonable, sometimes it's a power play.
- Buyer asks for unprotected indemnification. "You indemnify us against all claims regardless of source" is not standard and not signable. Negotiate it down or walk.

Part 5 — The trial pilot structure

The 30-day pilot is the standard mechanism for converting a discovery-call "interested" into a real buyer relationship. Done well, the pilot is structured so both parties have skin in the game, definitions are explicit, and the outcome is unambiguous at the end.

The pilot agreement (1-2 pages)

Even before the full LPA, formalize the pilot terms in writing. Sections:

Pilot scope

- Volume: "[Operator] will deliver between [N min] and [N max] leads matching the spec below over [30 calendar days starting [date]]."
- Geography and vertical: specific MSAs, specific sub-vertical.
- Delivery method: phone warm transfer / form post / scheduled callback — pick one for the pilot.

Qualification spec (the most critical section)

Write the qualification spec in concrete, testable terms. NOT "homeowner with HVAC need" but: "Owner of the residential property at the address provided, single-family or condo, with HVAC system 8 or more years old, replacement timeline of 0-90 days, not currently engaged with another contractor for this project, located in [list of MSAs]."

Pricing

- Pilot rate (often 80-90% of your standard rate as a goodwill gesture).
- Returns policy: "Buyer may return any lead failing the qualification spec within 72 hours of delivery with documented reason. Returns under [X%] of pilot volume are honored without dispute."
- Payment terms for pilot: typically Net 7 or even prepaid, given no track record.

Success criteria

Both sides agree, in writing, on what "the pilot succeeded" looks like:

- Qualification accuracy: [X%] of leads delivered match the spec.
- Buyer-side conversion: track buyer's conversion from your leads vs. their average — informational only, not a contractual gate.
- Dispute rate: under [Y%] over the pilot period.
- Communication and responsiveness: subjective but documented.

End-of-pilot decision

- Either side may decline to continue, no penalty.
- If continuing: 14-day window to negotiate and sign the full LPA.
- Pilot terms expire on day 31; no further deliveries until LPA is signed.

Why pilots work

- Reduces the buyer's perceived risk dramatically. "30 days, 5-10 leads, you can walk" is a much smaller decision than signing a 12-month LPA.
- Creates a forcing function for both sides. Bad fits surface within 30 days; good fits build mutual trust at low stakes.
- Generates real performance data. By day 30, both sides have actual numbers instead of marketing claims.
- Reveals operational alignment. If their intake team doesn't return calls promptly, you find out in the pilot — and you can address it before signing a long-term agreement.

Common pilot mistakes

- Vague qualification spec. The single biggest cause of pilot failure. Pin it down BEFORE the first lead ships.
- Volume too high. 5-10 leads is a meaningful test; 50+ is a commitment you shouldn't make on day one. Resist the buyer's instinct to scale fast.
- No defined return policy. Without one, every borderline lead becomes a fight. Bake the policy into the pilot agreement.
- Net 30 payment terms. Don't agree to long terms during a pilot — your cash cushion can't absorb it.

Part 6 — The negotiation playbook

After a successful pilot, both sides have proven enough to sign a real Lead Purchase Agreement. The negotiation that follows determines your margins, your risk exposure, and your scalability for years. Treat it as the highest-leverage 4-8 hours of work you'll do in your first year.

The Sample Lead Purchase Agreement deliverable covers the full clause-by-clause structure of the contract itself. This section is the NEGOTIATION layer — what to give on, what to hold on, what to ask for in return.

Negotiation principle 1 — Trade, don't concede.

If the buyer asks for a longer return window, ask for something in return (longer payment term, higher rate, exclusivity on a sub-vertical). Every concession should be paired with a get. Buyers expect this — and respect operators who negotiate like adults.

Negotiation principle 2 — Give on form, hold on substance.

Form things you can give on: pilot rate, marketing names, reporting frequency, the boilerplate in the contract. Substance things to hold on: TCPA representations and audit rights (these protect BOTH sides — never weaken them), indemnification scope (your counsel will tell you the defensible range; stay within it), qualification spec precision, payment timing.

Specific negotiations and how to handle them

Negotiation A — Pricing

Buyer will almost always come in 15-30% below your standard rate. Standard counter:

> *"I hear you on the rate. Here's what I can do: we'll honor [proposed rate] for the first 30 days post-pilot while we both validate the quality. After that, we re-rate to [your standard rate] based on the observed acceptance rate and dispute rate. If those numbers don't meet our agreed thresholds, the rate stays at [proposed rate]. Fair?"*

Why this works: aligns rate with performance. Gives the buyer the lower number short-term. Protects your margin if you actually deliver.

Negotiation B — Return windows

Standard return windows are 24-72 hours for phone-qualified leads, 7-14 days for form leads. Buyers always push for longer.

> *"Longer return windows make it harder for me to track unit economics. What if we keep the standard return window at [your standard] but add a no-fault credit pool? You get [X%] of monthly volume back as flex credit if your downstream conversion drops below [threshold]. That covers your edge cases without me losing my pricing discipline."*

Negotiation C — Indemnification scope

Buyers' counsel typically pushes broad indemnification clauses. Resist.

> *"My counsel won't sign mutual indemnification with that scope. Here's what we can do: I indemnify against TCPA, FTC Reviews Rule, and consumer-data-handling violations originating from MY intake processes. You indemnify against violations originating from YOUR downstream sales process, intake handling, and consumer communication. Mutual, parallel, defensible from both sides. Send to my counsel; we redline in 48 hours."*

Negotiation D — Exclusivity

Buyers often want geographic or sub-vertical exclusivity. Almost always a bad deal for a new operator — it caps your upside without proportional protection.

> *"I'll consider geographic exclusivity in [specific narrow geo] in exchange for a 25% rate premium and a minimum monthly volume guarantee of [N] leads. Below that volume, exclusivity expires automatically the next month. No exclusivity without volume commitment — I have to keep the option to deliver to other buyers if you can't absorb the supply."*

Negotiation E — Audit and data rights

Hold firm. Audit rights protect both sides. Standard language:

> *"Each party has the right to audit the other's compliance-related records on 14 days written notice, no more than once per quarter, at the requesting party's expense. Records reviewed: consent capture, DNC scrubs, recording archives. Standard mutual NDA covers what's shared."*

Negotiation F — Payment terms

Net 30 sounds standard. It's expensive for a new operator. Counter:

> *"Net 30 works long-term; for the first three months I'm asking for Net 14. After 90 days of clean payment history, we move to Net 30 if you prefer. This protects me from cash crunch while we're still building track record."*

Negotiation G — Termination clauses

Buyers usually want at-will termination with short notice. Acceptable for new operators (you want the flexibility too), but include a wind-down provision.

> *"30-day notice for at-will termination on either side. Termination doesn't void leads already delivered or in pipeline — those continue under the contracted terms. No new lead obligations after the notice period."*

Part 7 — The reference-call workaround

Sophisticated buyers will ask for references before signing. New operators have a chicken-and-egg problem: no references because no past buyers; no past buyers because no references.

Three approaches that work.

Approach A — Substitute proof-of-work for references

Instead of a former-buyer reference, offer evidence the buyer can verify directly:

- Sample leads (anonymized PII) with full consent documentation — the buyer can see exactly what your output looks like.
- Live demo of your intake process — agree to record one of your actual intake calls (with consumer permission) and let the buyer hear the quality.
- Side-by-side TrustedForm certificates from multiple recent leads showing the consistent capture pattern.
- Your compliance documentation — DNC scrubbing process, recording retention policy, indemnification posture. Concrete, technical, real.

> *"I won't have buyer references in our category until we close our first 3-5 buyers. What I CAN offer is direct proof: I'll send you the last 10 leads we shipped, anonymized, with full consent docs attached. You can evaluate the quality directly instead of trusting someone else's evaluation."*

Approach B — Adjacent references

References don't have to be lead-vendor references specifically. Adjacent ones that work:

- Past employer or business partner who can vouch for your professional reliability.
- Counsel or accountant who has worked with you for 12+ months and can confirm your professionalism on the business-management side.
- Vendor relationships from any prior business (your call-center vendor, your LMS vendor, your hosting provider) who can confirm you pay invoices and operate honestly.
- Industry peers from communities (LeadsCouncil, vertical-specific Slack) who know your work indirectly.

Approach C — The pilot as the reference

After 1-2 buyers complete a pilot and stay on as long-term customers, ASK them to be references. Most will say yes if you ask at the right moment (the 90-day mark, after they've confirmed they're happy).

> *"It's been 90 days. I wanted to ask — would you be willing to be a reference for me when I'm pursuing new buyer relationships in [other geographies / other sub-verticals]? I'd never name you to a competitor of yours, but for buyers in adjacent spaces, your honest experience would help me get past the no-references chicken-and-egg."*

Most buyers, if you've delivered well, say yes. The early references become disproportionately valuable for the next 12 months of business development.

Part 8 — Conference strategy

LeadsCon (the dominant general lead-gen conference, held twice a year in Las Vegas and Manhattan) plus vertical-specific conferences are where a meaningful portion of buyer-vendor relationships actually get formed. Operators who work conferences well can close 1-3 buyer relationships per event.

Pre-conference (4-6 weeks before)

- Get the attendee list (sometimes published, often available to sponsors, occasionally for purchase). Cross-reference with your target list from Part 1.
- Identify 10-15 specific buyers you want to meet. Build a tiered list: Tier 1 (5 you'd cancel everything else for); Tier 2 (next 5); Tier 3 (rest).
- Reach out to all 15 BEFORE the conference. Subject line: "At LeadsCon next month — coffee?" Email: 80 words, propose a specific time slot or two.
- Book hotel within walking distance of the venue. Hallway hours and after-hours bar meetings produce more deals than the official sessions.
- Pre-write the conference-floor 30-second intro (Part 2). Practice it out loud until it's natural.

During the conference (typically 2-3 days)

Day 1 — Reconnaissance

- Walk every booth. Note who's there, what they're selling, who their best people are.
- Attend 2-3 sessions specifically chosen because target buyers are speaking or attending.
- Find the unofficial hangout (almost always a specific bar 1-2 blocks from the venue). Be there 5-8 PM.

Day 2 — Concentrated outreach

- Show up to the meetings you pre-booked, on time, prepared.
- Between meetings, work the floor — introduce yourself to 15-20 new people using the 30-second script.
- Attend the official evening event (the headline party) AND the 2-3 unofficial after-parties. Most deals start at unofficial events.

Day 3 — Follow-up planning

- Capture every business card and conversation in a structured CRM entry. By the end of day 3, you should have 30-50 new entries.
- Schedule follow-up emails to go out within 5 business days of conference end. Reference the conversation specifically ("Coffee outside the Aria — talking about Tampa HVAC supply").

Conference-specific tactics that work

- Don't have a booth in your first year. Booths are expensive ($15k-$50k+) and trap you in one place. Walk the floor instead.
- Sponsor a small evening event with 3-4 other operators. Pooling 10-15k each gets you a 30-person dinner where every attendee is a high-value prospect.
- Volunteer to speak. Even on a panel. Even unpaid. Speakers get disproportionate visibility relative to the time investment.
- Stay until the LAST day. Many attendees leave early; the last-day floor is where high-quality conversations finally have space.

Vertical-specific conference list

- LeadsCon (general lead generation, twice yearly) — must-attend regardless of vertical.
- Mass Torts Made Perfect (legal/PI, Florida, twice yearly) — required for PI operators.
- Service World Expo (HVAC, plumbing, electrical, annual) — required for home services.
- AHIP (health insurance, including Medicare, annual) — required for Medicare lead-gen.
- NADA Show (automotive, annual) — required for auto lead-gen.
- Inman Connect (real estate, twice yearly) — required for real-estate lead-gen.
- ITA Insurance Marketing & Technology Summit — emerging important conference.

Part 9 — The first-year buyer roadmap

A reasonable target for a competent new operator: 1 buyer signed and producing in month 1-2, 3 buyers signed and producing by month 6, 8-12 buyer relationships by month 12. The roadmap below is the operating cadence to hit those numbers.

Month 1 — Land the first buyer

- Build the target list of 50-80 prospects (Part 1). Score and prioritize.
- Send Email #1 to the top 20 prospects. LinkedIn-connect to all 20.
- Follow Day-3-7-12-16-21 sequence (Part 2). Track replies in CRM.
- By end of month: 2-5 calls scheduled. 1-2 in pilot-discussion stage. 0-1 pilot signed.
- Goal: by end of month, you have at least one verbal commitment to start a pilot.

Month 2 — Deliver the pilot

- Sign the first pilot agreement (Part 5).
- Deliver pilot leads against the agreed qualification spec. Don't try to scale yet — focus 100% on quality.
- Communicate proactively. Daily summary to the buyer on what was delivered, what was qualified, what came back. Buyers don't expect this — they remember vendors who do it.
- By end of month: pilot complete. Decision point on whether to sign the full LPA.

Month 3 — Convert and expand

- Negotiate and sign the full LPA with the first buyer (Part 6).
- Continue delivery at pilot quality, expand volume gradually.
- Begin outreach to the NEXT batch of 30 prospects. Reference the first buyer where allowed.
- Apply to speak at LeadsCon or your vertical's next conference.

Month 4-6 — Add buyers 2 and 3

- Goal: 3 buyers actively producing by end of month 6.
- First conference attendance during this window. Book 10-15 pre-conference meetings.
- Ask your first buyer for permission to reference them (after 90 days, Part 7C).
- Diversify the routing: implement geo+tier waterfall (Module 5 Cold-to-Warm Playbook, Part 5) once you have 2+ buyers in any vertical/geo.

Month 7-12 — Scale to 8-12 buyers

- Outreach cadence becomes routine: every 30 days, fresh batch of 20-30 new prospects.
- Attend 1-2 more conferences in your vertical.
- Begin publishing operator content (newsletter, LinkedIn posts, podcast guest spots) — see Modern & Emerging Channels Section 6.3.
- Reference list now has 3-5 buyers willing to vouch for your work. Use this in outreach.
- Begin negotiating tier-1 buyer relationships — the larger firms that wouldn't return your call in month 1 will now.

What can go wrong

- First pilot fails. Most common cause: vague qualification spec. Mitigation: insist on precision before signing the pilot agreement.
- First buyer pulls volume unexpectedly. Don't panic. Use the displacement as forcing function to land buyer #2 faster. Diversification reduces blast radius.
- Conferences yield no commitments. Common in the first year — relationships take 2-3 conferences to mature. Plan the year-2 conference circuit before assessing year-1 ROI.
- Cash runs short before the second buyer signs. Mitigation: start with adequate capital (Module 7 covers the four capital scenarios in detail). Don't try to bootstrap with less than the recommended floor.

Closing — what to do in the next 72 hours

If you've read this playbook end to end, you now know more about landing first buyer relationships than 80% of operators currently doing it. Most don't have a target list. Most don't run pilots. Most negotiate the LPA from a defensive position. You don't have to.

Three things to do in the next three days:

19. Build your target list. Forty names, scored on the Part 1 framework. Today.
20. Write your one-pager. Use the Part 3 template. Have someone in your network read it tomorrow and tell you if it's specific enough.
21. Send Email #1 to your top five prospects. The day after tomorrow. The longer you wait, the more your activation energy compounds against you.

Then keep going. The operators who land their first buyer fastest are not the most talented — they're the ones who started sending outreach instead of refining their pitch indefinitely. Action compounds; rumination doesn't.

— Lorenzo
Lead Broker Blueprint